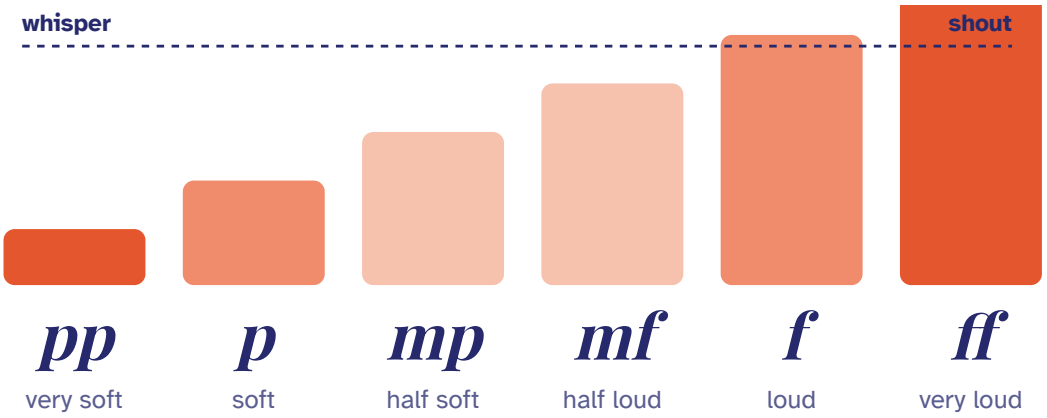
PART III · EXPRESSION · 1

Loud and soft

A voice can whisper, chat or shout. Music does the same, and small Italian words tell you which: the **dynamics**. They sit under the notes, shortened to one or two letters.

THE SECRET

Six steps, from a whisper to a shout: pp p mp mf f ff. m means half.



Six steps from a whisper to a shout
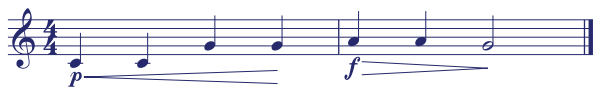
SIGN	SAY IT	HOW IT SOUNDS
pp	**pianissimo**	very soft
p	**piano**	soft
mp	**mezzo-piano**	half soft: a little louder than *p*
mf	**mezzo-forte**	half loud: a little softer than *f*
f	**forte**	loud
ff	**fortissimo**	very loud

THE RULE

p is soft, f is loud; m (mezzo) means half; a second letter means very. A sign lasts until the next one.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 1 · CONTINUED

Growing and fading



A hairpin that opens grows louder; one that closes fades. From *p* to *f* and back.



The same idea in words: *cresc.* and dashes, then *ff*.

SIGN	NAME	WHAT YOU DO
	**crescendo** (*cresc.*)	getting louder, little by little
	**diminuendo** (*dim.*, *decresc.*)	getting softer, little by little
sfz* / *sf	**sforzando**	one note made suddenly strong
fp	**forte-piano**	loud, then soft at once
subito p	**subito**	“suddenly”: *subito p*, suddenly soft

EXAMPLE 1

Which is louder: mp or mf?
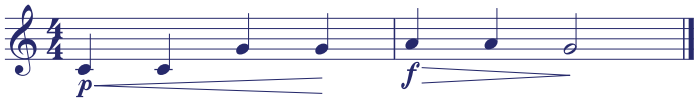
mp ***mf*** ?

1. **m means half.** Half of what?
2. **p is soft, f is loud.**
3. **So which half** is louder?

mf, half loud, is louder than **mp**, half soft. Both sit in the middle of the ladder.

EXAMPLE 2

What happens across the hairpins?



?

1. **Find the start:** which sign?
2. **The first hairpin opens** to which sign?
3. **The second hairpin closes.** What happens?

Start *p*, grow through bar 1 into *f*, then **fade** through bar 2.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

pp → ***ff***
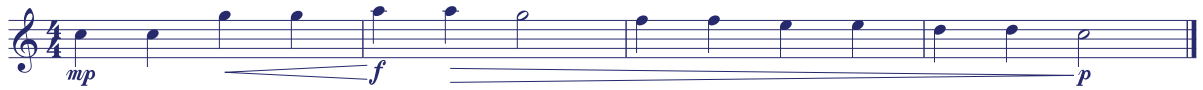
One note, six ways.

Play Middle C *pp*, then *p*, *mp*, *mf*, *f*, *ff*. Six different steps? Then come back down.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Where is the loudest note?



?

1. **Start:** *mp*.
2. **Follow the hairpin** to its sign.
3. **Then the long hairpin closes** to which sign?

The **first A in bar 2**, at *f*. From the next note the tune fades all the way to *p*.

GAME

Soft to loud

1	2	3	4	5	6
mf	*pp*	*f*	*p*	*ff*	*mp*

Put the six signs in order from the softest to the loudest.

Answer: pp · p · mp · mf · f · ff.
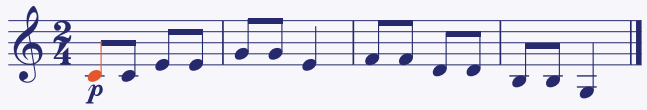
HOW TO

Practise a crescendo

1. **Play five notes up**, C to G, all *p*.
2. **Now grow** one step on each note: *p* to *f*.
3. **Come back down** the same notes, fading to *p*, without slowing down.

YOU KNOW THIS

Haydn's "Surprise" Symphony



The tune tiptoes along softly, then comes again even softer, *pp*. Just as everyone relaxes, the whole orchestra crashes in with one **ff** chord: the surprise that gave the symphony its name.

Try it. Hum it very softly, then clap once, as loud as you can.

THINK OF IT Dynamics are a volume knob with six clicks. Turn it with the weight of your arm, not by hitting harder.

TRAP

- × Playing everything *mf*: each sign is a different step.
- × Speeding up in a crescendo: louder is not faster.

SEE ALSO

Touch p. 75 · Pulse and tempo p. 46

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Dynamics